

Accenture / FAFSA

Improving FAFSA Usability for Millions of Students and Families

A mixed-methods UX research case study focused on making a high-stakes federal form clearer, more accessible, and easier to complete.

The FAFSA is one of the most important forms many students and families complete each year. It can determine access to federal student aid, influence college affordability, and shape major life decisions.

At Accenture Federal Services, I worked as a Senior UX Researcher supporting FAFSA experiences used by millions of students, parents, and contributors. My work focused on understanding where users struggled across the form experience, identifying opportunities to improve clarity and completion, and translating research into actionable recommendations for product, content, design, and development teams.

Because the FAFSA is a high-stakes public form, the work required careful attention to accessibility, comprehension, user confidence, and the realities of people completing the form under stress.

Project Snapshot

Project / Client: FAFSA / Federal Student Aid digital experiences through Accenture Federal Services

Timeline: December 2023 – April 2025

Role: Senior UX Researcher

Team / Stakeholders: Product, design, content, development, functional, communications, and federal client teams

Problem Space: Improving the clarity, accessibility, and completion experience of a high-stakes federal financial aid form used by millions of students and families

Methods: Usability testing, A/B testing, concept testing, survey research, behavioral analysis, qualitative synthesis, quantitative synthesis

Tools: Dscout, InVision, Medallia, Figma, Google Analytics, Miro, Microsoft Office

Outputs: Research plans, usability findings, A/B test insights, prioritized recommendations, stakeholder readouts, product/content/design recommendations

Outcome / Impact: Research recommendations contributed to an 18% increase in reported user satisfaction and a 15% reduction in abandonment

Focus Areas: Public sector UX, accessibility, form optimization, mixed-methods research, high-stakes digital services

The Challenge

FAFSA is not a casual digital experience. Users come to the form with different levels of financial knowledge, family support, technical confidence, accessibility needs, and emotional stress.

The challenge was not just helping users complete a form. It was helping them understand what was being asked, feel confident in their responses, and move through the experience without avoidable confusion or friction.

Our broader research question was:

How might we make the FAFSA experience clearer, more accessible, and easier to complete for students and families navigating a high-stakes financial aid process?

My Role

As Senior UX Researcher, I led and supported mixed-methods research across FAFSA form experiences, including the 2024–25 and 2025–26 cycles.

My role included planning research, conducting usability testing, synthesizing qualitative and quantitative findings, analyzing behavioral and satisfaction data, facilitating cross-functional alignment, and turning insights into prioritized product recommendations.

I worked closely with product, content, design, development, functional, communications, and client teams to ensure research findings were actionable and connected to real implementation decisions.

Research Approach

We used a mixed-methods approach because no single method could fully explain the user experience.

Usability testing helped us understand where users struggled in the moment. Surveys and satisfaction data helped us understand broader patterns. Analytics and behavioral data helped us identify where users were dropping off, hesitating, or taking unexpected paths. A/B testing helped evaluate specific design and content changes.

Our research included:

Moderated and unmoderated usability testing

A/B testing of design and content variations

Concept testing for proposed experience changes

Survey research and satisfaction analysis

Behavioral analysis through tools like Google Analytics and Medallia

Cross-functional synthesis and prioritization

Across the work, I tested with more than 70 participants, including diverse user groups such as first-generation students and individuals with disabilities.

Key Research Questions

We focused on questions like:

Where are users getting confused or stuck?

Which parts of the form create unnecessary anxiety or uncertainty?

Do users understand what information is required and why?

Are users able to review, edit, save, and submit with confidence?

Where can content, interaction design, or page structure reduce friction?

How do different user groups experience the form differently?

These questions helped us look beyond task completion alone and evaluate whether users truly understood what they were doing.

Key Research Findings

1. Users needed more confidence before high-stakes actions.

Users were often cautious near review, signature, and submission moments. These were not just functional steps — they carried emotional weight because users wanted to avoid making a mistake that could affect their financial aid.

This created an opportunity to better prepare users before they reached final review and signature moments.

2. Review experiences needed to be easier to scan and act on.

Users needed to quickly understand what they had entered, what still needed attention, and how to make changes. When review pages were too dense or unclear, users had a harder time feeling confident that the form was complete and accurate.

3. Edit pathways needed to be more visible.

When users noticed something they wanted to change, they needed a clear and obvious way to edit it. Ambiguous edit affordances created avoidable friction and reduced confidence.

4. Save and return behavior needed to feel clearer.

Because FAFSA can involve multiple contributors and information sources, users do not always complete the form in one sitting. Making “Save & Return” behavior more visible and understandable helped support realistic completion patterns.

5. Signature language needed to adapt to the user’s context.

Users needed clearer, more relevant language around signature moments. Dynamic signature text helped reduce ambiguity by making the experience feel more specific to the user’s role and task.

6. Contributor-related content needed careful placement.

Contributor information played an important role in the form experience. We tested placement and presentation of contributor cards to understand where users were most likely to notice, understand, and act on the information.

Research-to-Design Recommendations

Based on research findings, I helped shape recommendations across several areas of the FAFSA experience.

Add an interstitial before review and signature.

We recommended adding a clearer transitional moment before users entered final review or signature steps. The goal was to reduce uncertainty and help users understand what was coming next.

Improve the review page.

We recommended making the review experience easier to scan, understand, and act on so users could confidently confirm their information before moving forward.

Clarify edit affordances.

We recommended making edit options more visible and intuitive so users could quickly correct information without feeling lost.

Strengthen the Save & Return CTA.

We recommended making Save & Return behavior more prominent and understandable, especially for users who needed to pause and come back later.

Use dynamic signature language.

We recommended tailoring signature language to the user's context so that students, parents, and contributors could better understand what they were signing and why.

Test contributor card placement.

We evaluated contributor card placement to determine where related information would be most useful and noticeable within the form experience.

Cross-Functional Collaboration

This work required close partnership across multiple teams.

I collaborated with:

Product teams to prioritize research questions and align recommendations with roadmap needs

Content teams to improve comprehension and reduce ambiguity

Design teams to evaluate page structure, flows, and interaction patterns

Development teams to understand feasibility and implementation constraints

Functional teams and client stakeholders to ensure recommendations aligned with policy, requirements, and operational needs

Because FAFSA is both a product and a public service, recommendations needed to balance user needs, technical realities, legal requirements, and accessibility expectations.

Impact

The research helped identify and resolve usability issues across FAFSA experiences used by millions of students and families.

The work contributed to:

An 18% increase in reported user satisfaction

A 15% reduction in abandonment

Improved accessibility and inclusivity across tested experiences

Clearer recommendations for product, content, design, and development teams

Stronger stakeholder alignment around user-centered improvements

The biggest impact was not only improving individual screens, but helping teams make better decisions based on evidence from real users.

Reflection

This project strengthened my ability to lead research for complex, high-stakes digital services.

I learned how important it is to design for confidence, not just completion. In a form like FAFSA, users need to understand where they are, what is being asked, what happens next, and whether they can trust that they are doing things correctly.

I also learned how powerful research can be when it brings product, content, design, development, and client teams into the same conversation. The most useful insights were not just observations about user behavior — they were recommendations that helped teams move forward with clarity.

What I'd Do Differently Today

If I were continuing this work, I would want to further connect usability findings to longitudinal behavioral data. I would also want to track how specific recommendations affected completion, satisfaction, confidence, and support-seeking behavior over time.

I would also explore more targeted testing with contributors, returning users, first-time applicants, and users with accessibility needs to better understand how different groups experience the form.

Project Card

Improving FAFSA Usability for Millions of Students and Families

Led mixed-methods UX research for FAFSA experiences used by 17M+ users. Conducted usability testing, A/B testing, concept testing, surveys, and behavioral analysis to identify friction, improve accessibility, and inform product recommendations that contributed to an 18% increase in satisfaction and a 15% reduction in abandonment.

Tags

UX Research · Mixed Methods · Usability Testing · A/B Testing · Accessibility · Public Sector UX · Form Optimization · Google Analytics · Dscout · Research Synthesis · Cross-Functional Collaboration